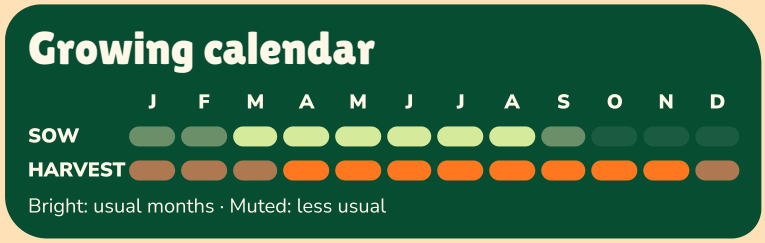
Vegetable Guides



How to use the guides

Reading the calendar

Bright shades show the usual sowing and harvest months for temperate climates: here, lowland England (US zones 8 to 9). Muted shades show less usual options for warmer climates. Use local conditions and the crop's advice to choose your timing.





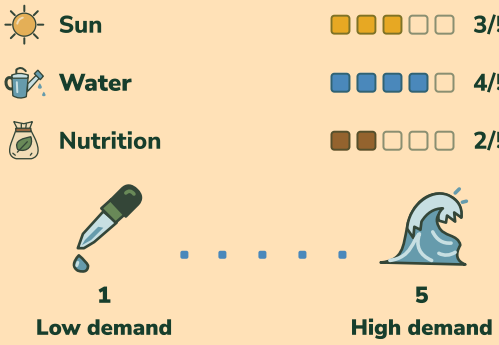
Difficulty rating

Difficulty reflects ease of growing and tolerance of adverse conditions. Radishes suit beginners; celery and cauliflower can defeat even experienced gardeners in a bad season.



Core needs

Too little sun, water or manure can damage some plants, while too much can harm others. Use the scales as a guide to each crop's needs.



Root Crops

Artichoke, Jerusalem.

HARVEST SEASONS
Autumn / Winter



Jerusalem artichokes are not true artichokes at all, but vigorous sunflower relatives grown for their knobbly underground tubers. They are hardy, reliable and useful for winter soups, stews and grated salads, with a sweet, nutty flavour which is not to everybody's taste and may not suit every digestion. The plants grow very tall in rich soil, making them useful as a screen or windbreak but also capable of robbing light from lower crops if planted in a long row. They are easy to grow from tubers, but hard to eradicate once established because even small pieces left in the soil can regrow.

Quick facts

Sow
Feb – Mar

Harvest
Nov – Jan

Plant spacing 12 in. between plants

Germination
2–4 weeks

Depth
6 in.

Ready in Late autumn; about 8–9 months after spring planting

Row spacing
3 ft between rows

Yield per plant
3-5 lb

Growing calendar

	J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
SOW												
HARVEST												

Bright: usual months · Muted: less usual

Core needs

1 = low · 5 = high

Sun	4/5
Water	2/5
Nutrition	3/5

Recommended varieties

Fuseau

Smooth, elongated tubers make this a practical kitchen choice, with less fiddly preparation than very knobbly selections.

Dwarf Sunray

A shorter-growing option with pale, relatively smooth tubers. Worth considering where tall Jerusalem artichokes would be awkward.

Small Wonder

A compact Jerusalem artichoke sold for containers and small plots, with tubers clustered near the stem.

Key risks

SCLEROTINIA ROT

Stem bases rot and may carry fluffy white mould with black, seed-like resting bodies.

SLUGS

Slugs may nibble spring shoots; established Jerusalem artichokes usually outgrow light leaf damage.

MICE

Mice may burrow among tubers in winter and eat stored or unlifted roots.

Growing guide · Artichoke, Jerusalem



Choose the site carefully.
Tall stems shade neighbours, and missed tubers regrow readily.

Leave tubers until they are needed.
They are hardy in the ground and provide a useful winter crop.

Soil & preparation

1. Light, sandy or free-draining soil suits the crop, provided it is not very acid or waterlogged in winter. Improve heavy clay before planting.
2. Prepare in autumn or early winter, removing perennial weeds and adding compost or well-rotted manure where humus is low. Sandy soil needs less preparation, though compost can improve the crop.

Sowing & planting

1 Set the tuber



Plant tubers in late winter or early spring. Choose a clump or block where tall stems will not shade lower crops.

2 Cover carefully



Cover the tubers carefully and water in. Remove stray tuber fragments when clearing the bed; they can regrow.

Tuber depth 6 in.
Rows 3 ft between rows
Plants / blocks 12 in. between plants

Looking after the crop

1. Hoe between young plants or mulch deeply against weeds, especially on heavy ground. Established plants on light soil need little attention.
2. Earth up the bases when stems are about 1 ft tall. Water during dry weather, especially on light soil.
3. In windy sites, support both sides of the row with wires between sturdy end canes. Tall stems can also make a temporary windbreak.
4. Leave flowers for pollinators if desired. Give weak plants an appropriate organic liquid feed during summer.

Harvesting & storage

- After leaves yellow in autumn, cut stems about 3 in. above soil. Use healthy tops as mulch or weave them into a temporary windbreak.
- Lift tubers as needed from late autumn through early spring. They are hardy, but frozen ground can prevent access: lift a supply before a hard freeze.
- Reserve sound tubers for replanting. Remove unwanted tubers and fragments carefully because even small pieces can regrow.
- When clearing a bed, revisit it through spring and repeatedly remove shoots and their tubers. One lifting may not clear the crop completely.

Pests & diseases

Problem	What to look for	What to do
SCLEROTINIA ROT	White mould and black bodies in rotting stems.	Remove infected plants and debris; avoid spreading affected soil.
SLUGS	Spring leaves nibbled; tubers hollowed.	Inspect and hand-pick; lift mature tubers before damage worsens.
MICE	Tubers are gnawed; tunnels may be present.	Rodent-proof stored tubers and inspect regularly.

Final tips

Keep the tall plants north of shorter vegetables so the screen does not rob them of light.

In severe frost, cover stem bases with straw or lift tubers after the tops have died back.

A manageable clump is often easier to accommodate than a long shading row.

Protect stored tubers from rodents and inspect them regularly for damage or decay.